庄子的梦

一个程序员的一个星期，和两千多年前的四个故事

Zhuangzi's Dreams

One programmer's week, and four stories from two thousand years ago

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Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 6 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 两千多年前，有一个人梦见自己变成了一只蝴蝶[†]。醒了以后，他问了自己一个问题，这个问题到今天也没有人能回答。两千多年以后的一个深秋的夜里，北京的一个程序员也做了一个梦。不过，在做梦之前，他得先下班。

凌晨[‡]两点

2 凌晨两点，顾帆[§]终于把最后一个问题修好了。办公室里只剩下他一个人，空调早就关了，屏幕的光照在他脸上，显得特别白。他今年二十九岁，在一家互联网公司当程序员，已经当了六年。这六年里，他时而加班到半夜，时而在会议室的沙发上睡到天亮，周末也常常被一个电话叫回公司。他写的代码，每天有几百万人在用；可是他自己，已经很久没有好好看过一次太阳了。

† 蝴蝶 *húdié* butterfly

‡ 凌晨 *língchén* small hours of the morning

§ 顾帆 *Gù Fān* Gu Fan

More than two thousand years ago, a man dreamed that he had turned into a butterfly. When he woke, he asked himself a question that no one has been able to answer to this day. More than two thousand years later, on a late-autumn night, a programmer in Beijing also had a dream. But before he could dream, he had to get off work. 1

Two in the Morning

At two in the morning, Gu Fan finally fixed the last problem. He was the only one left in the office. The air conditioning had long since been switched off, and the light of the screen made his face look especially pale. He was twenty-nine, and had been a programmer at an internet company for six years. In those six years he had sometimes worked until midnight and sometimes slept on the meeting-room sofa until dawn, and at weekends a single phone call often summoned him back to the office. Millions of people used the code he wrote every day; but he himself had not had a proper look at the sun in a long time. 2

3 他关上电脑，拿出手机，打开了一封写了三个月的信。信里只有一句话：“我决定辞职。”这封信他改过很多次：有时候写得很长，把这些年的辛苦和不开心都写进去；有时候只写一句，因为觉得说多了也没用。今天晚上，他终于不想再改了。他告诉自己：明天早上就把它发出去。至于辞职以后做什么，他还没有想好。也许回江西†老家，也许去南方，也许什么都不做，先睡一个月再说。

4 从写字楼出来，街上空空的，一辆出租车也没有。十一月的风已经很冷了，他把手放进口袋里，沿着马路慢慢往地铁站走。地铁早就停了，他也不知道自己为什么要往那儿走，也许只是习惯罢了。地铁站旁边有一家二十四小时营业的小商店，门口的灯下坐着一位老人，面前的地上摆着几十本旧书。凌晨‡两点在街上卖书？顾帆§不禁停下了脚步。

† 江西 *Jiāngxī* Jiangxi (province)
‡ 凌晨 *língchén* small hours of the morning
§ 顾帆 *Gù Fān* Gu Fan

He shut down the computer, took out his phone and opened a letter he had been writing for three months. It said only one thing: "I have decided to resign." He had rewritten it many times. Sometimes it was long, with all the hard work and unhappiness of these years poured into it; sometimes it was a single sentence, because saying more seemed pointless. Tonight he no longer wanted to change it. He told himself: tomorrow morning, I'll send it. As for what he would do after resigning, he hadn't decided. Perhaps go back to his home village in Jiangxi, perhaps go south, perhaps do nothing at all and simply sleep for a month first. 3

When he came out of the office building, the street was empty. There wasn't a single taxi. The November wind was already cold. He put his hands in his pockets and walked slowly along the road toward the subway station. The trains had stopped long ago, and he didn't know why he was heading there. Perhaps it was only habit. Next to the station was a small shop open twenty-four hours, and under the light by its door sat an old man with a few dozen old books laid out on the ground in front of him. Selling books on the street at two in the morning? Gu Fan couldn't help stopping. 4

5 “这么晚了，还有人买书吗？”他问。老人笑了笑：“没有。人老了，睡不着，出来坐坐罢了。”顾帆[†]蹲下来，随手翻了翻。大部分是旧杂志和过时的电脑书，只有一本薄薄的小书，书皮上画着一只蝴蝶[‡]，下面写着两个字：《庄子[§]》。书里每一页都有画，画旁边是简单的白话[¶]，还有一两句古文[*]。“十块钱。”老人说，“这本书没什么用，看了也不能帮你赚钱。”顾帆笑了：“没用的东西，正是我现在最需要的。”他付了钱，把书放进了包里。

蝴蝶

6 回到租的房子，已经快三点了。顾帆躺在床上，本来想马上睡觉，却怎么也睡不着。人越累，脑子反而越清醒。

† 顾帆 *Gù Fān* Gu Fan
‡ 蝴蝶 *húdié* butterfly
§ 庄子 *Zhuāngzǐ* Zhuangzi (the thinker, and his book)
¶ 白话 *báihuà* modern vernacular Chinese
* 古文 *gǔwén* classical Chinese

"Does anyone still buy books this late?" he asked. The old man smiled. 5
"No. When you get old, you can't sleep. I just come out to sit for a while, that's all." He squatted down and idly leafed through them. Most were old magazines and out-of-date computer books; only one, a thin little book, had a butterfly drawn on its cover, and beneath it two characters: Zhuangzi. Every page had pictures, and beside them were simple explanations in modern Chinese, along with a line or two of classical Chinese. "Ten yuan," said the old man. "This book's not much use. Reading it won't help you make money." Gu Fan laughed. "Something useless is exactly what I need right now." He paid and put the book in his bag.

The Butterfly

By the time he got back to his rented flat, it was nearly three. Gu Fan lay 6
down meaning to fall asleep at once, but he simply couldn't. The more tired he was, the more awake his mind became.

6 他打开那本《庄子[1]》，从第一页看起。书上说，庄子[2]名叫庄周，大约生活在两千三百多年前的战国[3]时代，是宋国[4]人。他只做过一个管理漆树园[5]的小官，日子过得很穷，据说有时候还得向别人借米。

7 据说，有一次，楚国[6]的国王听说庄子很有本事，派了两个官员[7]去请他，想把整个国家的事都交给他管。那时庄子正在河边钓鱼[8]，头也没有回，只问了一句："我听说楚国有一只神龟[9]，已经死了三千年。国王把它包在布里，放进盒子，摆在庙[10]里最高的地方。你们说，这只龟[11]是愿意死了让人尊敬，还是愿意活着，在泥里拖着尾巴爬？"两个官员说："当然愿意活着。"庄子说："那你们回去吧。我也要在泥里拖着尾巴爬。"

1 庄子 *Zhuāngzǐ* Zhuangzi (the thinker, and his book)
2 庄周 *Zhuāng Zhōu* Zhuang Zhou, Zhuangzi's own name
3 战国 *Zhànguó* the Warring States (475–221 BC)
4 宋国 *Sòngguó* the state of Song
5 漆树园 *qīshùyuán* lacquer-tree garden
6 楚国 *Chǔguó* the state of Chu
7 官员 *guānyuán* official
8 钓鱼 *diàoyú* to fish
9 神龟 *shénguī* sacred tortoise
10 庙 *miào* temple, shrine
11 龟 *guī* tortoise

He opened the Zhuangzi and began at the first page. The book said that 6
Zhuangzi's name was Zhuang Zhou, that he lived about 2,300 years ago in the Warring States period, and that he came from the state of Song. He only ever held a minor post looking after a lacquer-tree garden, and he lived in poverty; it is said that at times he even had to borrow grain from others.

It is said that once the king of Chu, hearing how able Zhuangzi was, sent 7
two officials to invite him, wishing to hand him the running of the whole state. Zhuangzi was fishing by a river at the time. Without even turning his head, he asked a single question: "I hear that Chu has a sacred tortoise that has been dead for three thousand years. The king keeps it wrapped in cloth, in a box, in the highest place in the temple. Tell me: would this tortoise rather be dead and honoured, or alive, dragging its tail through the mud?" "Alive, of course," said the two officials. "Then go back," said Zhuangzi. "I too will drag my tail through the mud."

顾帆[1]不禁笑了起来：原来两千多年前，就已经有人不想上班了。

再往后翻几页，就是那个最有名的故事。画上是一个在树下睡觉的人，他头上飞着一只蝴蝶[2]。白话[3]是这样写的：从前，庄周[4]梦见自己变成了一只蝴蝶，一只快乐的蝴蝶，时而飞上天空，时而落在花上，完全忘了自己是庄周。忽然，他醒了过来，发现自己明明是庄周。于是他想：究竟是庄周在梦里变成了蝴蝶，还是蝴蝶在梦里变成了庄周？旁边的古文[5]是：“不知[6]周之[7]梦为胡蝶[8]与，胡蝶之梦为周与？”

看着看着，顾帆睡着了。他梦见自己也变成了一只蝴蝶，飞在老家的油菜花[9]田上。四月的阳光照在黄色的花上，风一吹，整片田就像水一样动了起来。

1 顾帆 *Gù Fān* Gu Fan
2 蝴蝶 *húdié* butterfly
3 白话 *báihuà* modern vernacular Chinese
4 庄周 *Zhuāng Zhōu* Zhuang Zhou, Zhuangzi's own name
5 古文 *gǔwén* classical Chinese
6 不知 *bùzhī* do not know
7 之 *zhī* (classical particle)
8 胡蝶 *húdié* butterfly (old spelling)
9 油菜花 *yóucàihuā* rapeseed flowers

Gu Fan couldn't help laughing. So even two thousand years ago, there were people who didn't want to go to work. 7

A few pages further on came the most famous story of all. The picture showed a man asleep under a tree, with a butterfly flying above his head. The modern text went like this: Once, Zhuang Zhou dreamed that he had become a butterfly, a happy butterfly, now flying up into the sky, now settling on a flower, quite forgetting that he was Zhuang Zhou. Suddenly he woke, and found that he was plainly Zhuang Zhou. And so he wondered: had Zhuang Zhou become a butterfly in a dream, or was a butterfly now dreaming that it was Zhuang Zhou? Beside it was the classical line: "I do not know whether Zhou dreamed he was a butterfly, or a butterfly is dreaming that it is Zhou." 8

Reading on and on, Gu Fan fell asleep. He dreamed that he too had become a butterfly, flying over the rapeseed fields of his home village. The April sun shone on the yellow flowers, and whenever the wind blew, the whole field moved like water. 9

9 他时而飞得很高，看见远处的小河和奶奶的房子；时而飞得很低，几乎碰到了花。没有会议，没有消息，也没有人问他“什么时候能上线[†]”。他仿佛又回到了七岁，又成了那个在田边追蝴蝶[‡]的男孩。只是这一次，他自己就是那只蝴蝶。

10 闹钟响了。早上七点半。顾帆[§]醒过来，看见的是灰色的天花板，和手机上四十七条没看的工作消息。他躺着没动。有好几秒，他真的不知道自己究竟是谁：是一个梦见自己变成蝴蝶的程序员，还是一只梦见自己变成程序员的蝴蝶？如果是一只蝴蝶，那这个梦也做得太长、太累了。他拿起手机，又看了看那封信，最后还是没有发。“再等一个星期吧。”他对自己说，“至少把这本书看完。”至于为什么是一个星期，他自己也说不清楚。

† 上线 *shàngxiàn* to go live (software)

‡ 蝴蝶 *húdié* butterfly

§ 顾帆 *Gù Fān* Gu Fan

Now he flew high and could see the little river in the distance and his grandmother's house; now he flew low, almost brushing the flowers. No meetings, no messages, and no one asking him "When can it go live?" It was as if he were seven again, the boy who chased butterflies at the edge of the fields. Only this time, he himself was the butterfly. 9

The alarm went off. Half past seven in the morning. Gu Fan woke to a grey ceiling, and forty-seven unread work messages on his phone. He lay there without moving. For several seconds he truly didn't know who he was: a programmer who had dreamed he was a butterfly, or a butterfly dreaming that it was a programmer? If he was a butterfly, this dream had gone on far too long, and was far too tiring. He picked up his phone and looked at the letter again, but in the end he didn't send it. "I'll wait another week," he told himself. "At least until I've finished this book." As for why it should be a week, he couldn't really have said himself. 10

鱼的快乐

11 星期二上午，组里开会，讨论一个新功能。产品经理想让应用每天晚上十点以后，再给用户多发两条消息。“数据说得很清楚，晚上发的消息，点开的人最多。”顾帆[†]觉得不对：“半夜收到那么多消息，谁会高兴？用户本来想睡觉，我们反而让他们更睡不着。”坐在他对面的何磊[‡]马上笑了。何磊是做数据分析的，比顾帆早两年进公司。两个人一起吃了几年午饭，也吵了几年架，什么事都能吵起来。

12 “你又不是用户，”何磊说，“你怎么知道用户不高兴？”“你又不是我，”顾帆说，“你怎么知道我不知道？”会议室里安静了一秒，接着大家都笑了。产品经理摇了摇头：“你们俩又来了。先试一个星期，至于以后还发不发，看了数据再说。”

† 顾帆 *Gù Fān* Gu Fan

‡ 何磊 *Hé Lěi* He Lei

The Joy of Fish

On Tuesday morning the team held a meeting to discuss a new feature. 11
The product manager wanted the app to send users two extra messages every evening after ten. "The data is very clear: messages sent at night get opened the most." Gu Fan didn't think it was right. "Who's happy to get that many messages in the middle of the night? Users want to sleep, and instead we keep them awake even longer." He Lei, who sat across from him, laughed at once. He Lei worked in data analysis and had joined the company two years before Gu Fan. The two of them had eaten lunch together for years, and argued for years too; they could argue about anything.

"You're not a user," said He Lei. "How do you know users aren't happy?" 12
"You're not me," said Gu Fan. "How do you know that I don't know?" The meeting room went quiet for a second, and then everyone laughed. The product manager shook her head. "Here you two go again. We'll try it for a week. As for whether we keep sending them, we'll decide when we've seen the data."

12 顾帆[†]也跟着笑，可是笑到一半，他忽然觉得刚才那几句话非常熟悉，好像在哪里听过。那天下午，他时而写几行代码，时而停下来发呆，却怎么也想不起来。

13 那天晚上，他在《庄子[‡]》里找到了答案。有一天，庄子和他的朋友惠子[§]在濠水[¶]的一座桥上散步。庄子看着桥下的鱼说："你看，这些鱼游得多自由、多轻松，这就是鱼的快乐啊。"惠子说："子非鱼，安知鱼之[*]乐？"——你又不是鱼，怎么知道鱼快乐呢？庄子说："子非我，安知我不知鱼之乐？"——你又不是我，怎么知道我不知道鱼快乐呢？顾帆不禁大笑起来。原来他和何磊[#]今天吵的这一架，两千多年前就有人吵过了，连句子都差不多。

† 顾帆 *Gù Fān* Gu Fan
‡ 庄子 *Zhuāngzǐ* Zhuangzi (the thinker, and his book)
§ 惠子 *Huìzǐ* Huizi, Zhuangzi's friend
¶ 濠水 *Háoshuǐ* the Hao River
* 之 *zhī* (classical particle)
\# 何磊 *Hé Lěi* He Lei

Gu Fan laughed along, but halfway through he suddenly felt that those few 12
lines were very familiar, as if he had heard them somewhere before. All that afternoon he would write a few lines of code and then stop and stare into space, but he just couldn't remember where.

That evening he found the answer in the Zhuangzi. One day Zhuangzi and 13
his friend Huizi were strolling on a bridge over the Hao River. Looking at the fish below the bridge, Zhuangzi said, "Look how freely and easily these fish swim. That is the joy of fish." Huizi said, "You are not a fish; how do you know the joy of fish?" In other words: you're not a fish, so how can you know that fish are happy? Zhuangzi said, "You are not me; how do you know that I do not know the joy of fish?" That is: you're not me, so how can you know that I don't know the fish are happy? Gu Fan couldn't help bursting out laughing. So the argument he and He Lei had had that day had already been fought two thousand years ago, almost word for word.

14 书上说，惠子[†]名叫惠施[‡]，是当时有名的思想家，还在魏国[§]当过大官。他最喜欢辩论，什么问题都要问个清楚。庄子[¶]和他几乎每次见面都要争，谁也说服不了谁。可是，他们一辈子都是朋友。据说惠子死后，有一次庄子经过他的墓，停下来对身边的人说：自从惠子走了，我就再也没有可以说话的人了。顾帆[*]合上书，想了很久。

15 第二天中午，他走到何磊[#]的桌子旁边：“走，吃饭去。昨天那个问题，我们还没吵完。”何磊抬起头，奇怪地看着他：“你今天怎么这么高兴？前几天你看起来还像要辞职一样。”“我在看一本书。”顾帆说，“书上说，天天跟你吵架的人，不一定是你的敌人；说不定，反而是最懂你的人。”何磊想了想：“你又不是我，你怎么知道我懂你？”两个人一起笑了，走进了电梯。

† 惠子 *Huìzǐ* Huizi, Zhuangzi's friend
‡ 惠施 *Huì Shī* Hui Shi
§ 魏国 *Wèiguó* the state of Wei
¶ 庄子 *Zhuāngzǐ* Zhuangzi (the thinker, and his book)
* 顾帆 *Gù Fān* Gu Fan
\# 何磊 *Hé Lěi* He Lei

The book said that Huizi's name was Hui Shi. He was a well-known thinker 14
of his day, and had held high office in the state of Wei. He loved nothing more than a debate, and had to get to the bottom of every question. He and Zhuangzi argued almost every time they met, and neither could ever convince the other. Yet they were friends all their lives. It is said that after Huizi died, Zhuangzi once passed his tomb, stopped, and said to those with him: since Huizi has gone, I have had no one left to talk to. Gu Fan closed the book and thought for a long time.

At noon the next day he went over to He Lei's desk. "Come on, let's go and 15
eat. We haven't finished arguing about yesterday's question." He Lei looked up and gave him a puzzled look. "Why are you so cheerful today? A few days ago you looked like you were about to quit." "I've been reading a book," said Gu Fan. "It says that someone who argues with you every day isn't necessarily your enemy. If anything, he may be the person who understands you best." He Lei thought about it. "You're not me. How do you know I understand you?" They both laughed and stepped into the lift.

没用的树

16 星期四下午，领导把顾帆†叫进了办公室。今年的绩效‡考核，顾帆拿了一个很低的分。领导说话很客气，可是意思很清楚：“你的技术没问题，就是做的东西……怎么说呢，用处不大。”他举了个例子：今年春天，顾帆花了两个月，把一个老系统的代码重新整理了一遍，还写了几十页的说明。“这些东西，用户看不见，老板也看不见。今年公司要的是速度，是新功能。”

17 最后，领导告诉他，从下个星期起，他不用再做新项目了，去维护那个老系统。公司里的人都明白，被派去维护老系统，就是说，你在这里已经不重要了。从办公室出来，顾帆觉得自己像一张用过的纸。回到座位上，他又打开了那封信。这一次，他的手指在“发送”上停了很久。

† 顾帆 *Gù Fān* Gu Fan

‡ 绩效 *jìxiào* work performance

The Useless Tree

On Thursday afternoon, his manager called Gu Fan into his office. In this year's performance review, Gu Fan had been given a very low score. His manager spoke politely, but the meaning was clear. "There's nothing wrong with your technical skills. It's just that the things you work on are... how shall I put it... not much use." He gave an example: this spring Gu Fan had spent two months tidying up the code of an old system, and had written dozens of pages of documentation as well. "Users can't see that sort of thing, and neither can the bosses. What the company wants this year is speed, and new features." 16

Finally his manager told him that from next week he would no longer work on new projects, but would go and maintain that old system. Everyone in the company understood that being sent to maintain an old system meant, in other words, that you no longer mattered there. Coming out of the office, Gu Fan felt like a sheet of used paper. Back at his desk, he opened the letter again. This time his finger hovered over "Send" for a long while. 17

18 “没用”这两个字，比加班、比半夜被叫醒都让他难受。这六年，他一直努力做一个有用的人：对公司有用，对项目有用，对父母有用。现在却有人告诉他，他认真做的事情，没什么用。可是他最后还是没有按下去。不是因为他想留下来，而是因为他不想就这样带着“没用”两个字离开。

19 那天晚上，他翻到了一棵树的故事。有一个木匠[†]，大家叫他匠石[‡]。有一次，他带着徒弟去齐国[§]，路上经过一座庙[¶]，庙前有一棵大栎树[*]。这棵树又高又粗，大得能给几千头牛挡太阳。来看它的人多得像赶集一样，可是匠石连看都不看，一直往前走。

20 徒弟追上去问：“师父，我跟您学了这么多年，从来没见过这么好的木头。您为什么看都不看？”

† 木匠 *mùjiang* carpenter
‡ 匠石 *Jiàng Shí* Carpenter Shi
§ 齐国 *Qíguó* the state of Qi
¶ 庙 *miào* temple, shrine
* 栎树 *lìshù* oak tree

The word "useless" hurt him more than the overtime, more than being wo- 18
ken in the middle of the night. For six years he had tried hard to be useful: useful to the company, useful to the project, useful to his parents. And now someone was telling him that the work he had done so carefully wasn't much use. But in the end he still didn't press it. Not because he wanted to stay, but because he didn't want to leave like this, carrying the word "useless" with him.

That night he turned to the story of a tree. There was a carpenter whom 19
people called Carpenter Shi. Once, on his way to the state of Qi with his apprentice, he passed a shrine, and in front of it stood a great oak. The tree was so tall and thick that it could shade several thousand oxen from the sun. So many people came to look at it that it was like a market day, but Carpenter Shi didn't so much as look, and walked straight on.

His apprentice ran to catch up and asked, "Master, in all the years I've stud- 20
ied with you, I've never seen such fine timber. Why won't you even look at it?"

20 匠石[1]说：“别说了，那是没用的树。用它做船，船会沉；做棺材[2]，很快就烂；做家具，很快就坏；做柱子，会生虫子。正因为它一点用也没有，才能活得这么久。”

21 那天夜里，大栎树[3]出现在匠石的梦里。它说：“你拿我跟那些‘有用’的树比吗？果树结了果子，人们就去打它、拉它的枝，它们因为有用，一辈子都很辛苦，往往活不到该活的年纪。”

“我想做一棵没用的树，已经想了很久，好几次差点儿被人砍[4]死，现在才终于做到了。这‘没用’，对我来说，正是最大的用处。”在这一篇的最后，庄子[5]写道：“人皆[6]知有用之[7]用，而莫[8]知无用之用也。”——人人都知道有用的用处，却没有人知道没用的用处。顾帆[9]看着这句话，不禁问自己：那么，我的“没用”，又有什么用呢？

1 匠石 *Jiàng Shí* Carpenter Shi
2 棺材 *guāncai* coffin
3 栎树 *lìshù* oak tree
4 砍 *kǎn* to chop
5 庄子 *Zhuāngzǐ* Zhuangzi (the thinker, and his book)
6 皆 *jiē* all (classical)
7 之 *zhī* (classical particle)
8 莫 *mò* no one (classical)
9 顾帆 *Gù Fān* Gu Fan

Carpenter Shi said, "Say no more. That's a useless tree. Make a boat of it and 20
the boat will sink; make a coffin and it will soon rot; make furniture and it will soon fall apart; make a pillar and it will get worms. It is precisely because it is no use at all that it has lived so long."

That night the great oak appeared in Carpenter Shi's dream. It said, "Are 21
you comparing me with those 'useful' trees? When fruit trees bear fruit, people beat them and pull at their branches. Because they are useful, their whole lives are hard, and they often don't live out their natural years." "I have been trying to be useless for a long time. Several times I was nearly chopped down, and only now have I finally succeeded. This 'uselessness' is, for me, the greatest use of all." At the end of this chapter, Zhuangzi wrote: "Everyone knows the use of the useful, but no one knows the use of the useless." Looking at the line, Gu Fan couldn't help asking himself: then what use is my "uselessness"?

庖丁†

22 下个星期一，顾帆‡搬到了九楼最里面的一张桌子，开始维护那个老系统。这个系统是公司最早的系统之一，十多年前就写好了，每天负责给几万家商店算钱、付钱，从来没有出过大问题。大家都叫它“老房子”：谁也不愿意住进去，可是谁也不敢把它拆掉。负责它的只有一个人：老宋§。老宋四十六岁，是组里年纪最大的程序员。年轻人在背后说，像他这样的人，早就该被“优化¶”了。可是老宋好像一点儿也不着急。他每天九点来，六点走，很少加班，桌子上总是放着一杯热茶。

23 星期三晚上，系统出了问题：有一部分商店的钱没有按时到账。组里一下子急了。两个年轻同事马上打开了十几个窗口，一行一行地查代码，查了两个小时，越查越乱。

† 庖丁 *Páo Dīng* Cook Ding
‡ 顾帆 *Gù Fān* Gu Fan
§ 老宋 *Lǎo Sòng* Old Song
¶ 优化 *yōuhuà* “optimised” (laid off)

Cook Ding

The following Monday, Gu Fan moved to a desk at the far end of the ninth 22
floor and began maintaining the old system. It was one of the company's earliest systems, written more than ten years before. Every day it worked out and paid what was owed to tens of thousands of shops, and it had never once had a serious problem. Everyone called it "the old house": nobody wanted to move in, but nobody dared to tear it down either. Only one person was in charge of it: Old Song. He was forty-six, the oldest programmer on the team. Behind his back the younger staff said that someone like him should have been "optimised" long ago. But Old Song didn't seem the least bit worried. He came in at nine, left at six, rarely worked overtime, and always had a cup of hot tea on his desk.

On Wednesday evening the system ran into trouble: some of the shops had 23
not received their money on time. The whole team was suddenly in a panic. Two young colleagues opened a dozen windows at once and went through the code line by line; after two hours of searching, things were only more confused.

23 老宋[1]来了以后，却不急着动手。他先给自己泡了一杯茶，然后坐在屏幕前，静静地看了二十分钟日志[2]。最后，他只改了三行代码。问题解决了。顾帆[3]在旁边看着，不禁问："您怎么知道是这三行？"老宋喝了一口茶，说："这个系统，我看了十二年了。它哪里结实，哪里有缝[4]，我心里都清楚。我不是比你们快，而是不走那些没用的路。"

24 那天晚上，顾帆读到了庖丁[5]的故事。庖丁是一个厨师。有一次，他给文惠君[6]解牛[7]——就是把一整头牛的肉和骨头分开。他的手、脚和身体，每一个动作都像在跳舞；刀进去的声音很有节奏，像音乐一样。文惠君看呆了："好啊！技术怎么能好到这种程度？"庖丁放下刀，说："臣[8]之[9]所好者道也，进乎技矣[10]。"——我喜欢的不是技术，而是"道"；道比技术又进了一步。

1 老宋 *Lǎo Sòng* Old Song
2 日志 *rìzhì* system log
3 顾帆 *Gù Fān* Gu Fan
4 缝 *fèng* crack, seam
5 庖丁 *Páo Dīng* Cook Ding
6 文惠君 *Wénhuì Jūn* Lord Wenhui
7 解牛 *jiěniú* to cut up an ox
8 臣 *chén* I, your servant (classical)
9 之 *zhī* (classical particle)
10 矣 *yǐ* (classical particle)

When Old Song arrived, though, he was in no hurry to start. First he made 23
himself a cup of tea, then sat in front of the screen and quietly read the logs for twenty minutes. In the end he changed just three lines of code. The problem was solved. Gu Fan, watching beside him, couldn't help asking, "How did you know it was those three lines?" Old Song took a sip of tea and said, "I've been looking at this system for twelve years. Where it's solid and where it has cracks, I know it all by heart. It's not that I'm faster than you; it's that I don't go down the roads that lead nowhere."

That night Gu Fan read the story of Cook Ding. Ding was a cook. Once 24
he was cutting up an ox for Lord Wenhui, that is, separating all the meat of a whole ox from its bones. Every movement of his hands, his feet and his body was like a dance, and the sound of the knife going in had a rhythm, like music. Lord Wenhui watched spellbound. "Wonderful! How can skill reach such a level?" Cook Ding put down his knife and said, "What your servant loves is the Way, which goes beyond skill." In other words: what I love is not technique but the Way, and the Way goes one step further than technique.

25 庖丁[†]说，他刚开始解牛[‡]的时候，眼里看到的只是一整头牛。三年以后，他再也看不到一整头牛了，看到的是牛身体里面的结构：哪里是骨头，哪里是空的。后来，人们就用“目无全牛[§]”这个成语，来说一个人的技术已经非常高了。现在，他不用眼睛看，而是用心去感觉。他按照牛身体本来的样子，让刀从骨头和骨头之间的空处进去，一点儿也不费力。

26 “好的厨师一年换一把刀，因为他们是用刀去切肉；普通的厨师一个月就得换一把，因为他们的刀总是硬碰骨头。我这把刀已经用了十九年，解过几千头牛，可是刀口还像刚磨过的一样。”骨头和骨头之间有空，刀口却薄得几乎没有一点厚，所以刀在里面走来走去，总有足够的地方。成语“游刃有余[¶]”，就是从这里来的。

† 庖丁 *Páo Dīng* Cook Ding

‡ 解牛 *jiěniú* to cut up an ox

§ 目无全牛 *mù wú quán niú* to see no whole ox (perfect mastery)

¶ 游刃有余 *yóurèn yǒuyú* to handle with ease

Ding said that when he first began cutting up oxen, all he saw was a whole 25
ox. After three years he never saw a whole ox again; what he saw was the structure inside its body: where the bones were, and where the empty spaces were. Later, people came to use the idiom "to see no whole ox" to say that someone's skill has become truly masterly. Now he no longer looked with his eyes but felt his way with his mind. Following the natural shape of the ox's body, he let the knife go in through the spaces between the bones, without the slightest effort.

"A good cook changes his knife once a year, because he cuts through meat. 26
An ordinary cook has to change his every month, because his knife keeps hacking against bone. I have used this knife for nineteen years and cut up several thousand oxen, yet its edge is as if it had just been sharpened." There are gaps between the bones, while the edge is so thin it has almost no thickness at all, so the knife can move about inside with room to spare. That is where the idiom "a blade moving with room to spare" comes from.

27 不过，庖丁[1]也说，每次碰到骨头和筋[2]长在一起、很难下刀的地方，他照样会小心起来：眼睛看准，动作放慢，刀轻轻一动，牛肉就像一堆土一样散开了。文惠君[3]听了说：“好啊！我听了庖丁的话，懂得了怎样养生[4]。”顾帆[5]合上书，想起了老宋[6]的那三行代码。

28 第二天，他把那天晚上的日志[7]从头看了一遍。看着看着，他发现系统里有很多注释[8]，写得清清楚楚，有的已经是十年前的了。更让他没想到的是，老宋的电脑旁边放着一份打印出来的文件，边上写满了字。那正是他春天写的那几十页说明。“这是……我写的？”他问。老宋笑了：“写得好啊，我天天看。年轻人都说这种东西没用，可是没有它，这么大的系统，我一个人哪里看得过来？”

1 庖丁 *Páo Dīng* Cook Ding
2 筋 *jīn* tendon
3 文惠君 *Wénhuì Jūn* Lord Wenhui
4 养生 *yǎngshēng* to nurture life
5 顾帆 *Gù Fān* Gu Fan
6 老宋 *Lǎo Sòng* Old Song
7 日志 *rìzhì* system log
8 注释 *zhùshì* comment (in code)

Still, Ding said, each time he came to a place where bone and tendon grew 27
together and it was hard to cut, he would grow careful all the same: his eyes fixed on the spot, his movements slowed, the knife moved ever so slightly, and the meat fell apart like a heap of earth. When Lord Wenhui heard this he said, "Wonderful! Listening to Cook Ding, I have learned how to nurture life." Gu Fan closed the book and thought of Old Song's three lines of code.

The next day he went through that night's logs again from the beginning. 28
As he read, he found that the system was full of comments, written with perfect clarity, some of them ten years old. What surprised him even more was a printed document lying beside Old Song's computer, its margins covered in handwriting. It was the very documentation, dozens of pages of it, that he had written in the spring. "Is this... mine?" he asked. Old Song smiled. "It's well written. I read it every day. The young ones all say this sort of thing is useless, but without it, how could I keep track of a system this big on my own?"

28 他喝了一口茶，又说：“很多人觉得我在这里也没用。至于有用没用，我早就不想了。我只想把这一件事做好。”顾帆[1]没有说话。他想起了那棵大栎树[2]，也想起了庖丁[3]那把用了十九年的刀。

醒来[4]

29 星期六早上，顾帆醒过来的时候，已经十点了。他整整睡了十个小时，没有做梦——没有蝴蝶[5]，也没有会议。这是这几年来他第一次睡得这么好。窗外的太阳很好。他躺着想：一个星期到了，那封信还在手机里。他起床洗了脸，把那本《庄子[6]》放进包里，坐地铁去了什刹海[7]。

1 顾帆 *Gù Fān* Gu Fan
2 栎树 *lìshù* oak tree
3 庖丁 *Páo Dīng* Cook Ding
4 醒来 *xǐnglái* to wake up
5 蝴蝶 *húdié* butterfly
6 庄子 *Zhuāngzǐ* Zhuangzi (the thinker, and his book)
7 什刹海 *Shíchàhǎi* Shichahai (lakes in central Beijing)

He sipped his tea and went on, "Plenty of people think I'm useless here too. 28
As for useful or useless, I stopped thinking about that long ago. I just want to do this one thing well." Gu Fan said nothing. He thought of the great oak, and of Cook Ding's knife that had lasted nineteen years.

Waking

On Saturday morning, when Gu Fan woke up, it was already ten o'clock. 29
He had slept for a full ten hours without dreaming: no butterflies, and no meetings either. It was the first time in years he had slept so well. The sun was bright outside the window. Lying there, he thought: the week is up, and the letter is still on my phone. He got up, washed his face, put the Zhuangzi in his bag, and took the subway to Shichahai.

30 十一月的什刹海†，游客不多。湖边的树叶子已经黄了，几个老人坐在水边聊天，远处有人在唱京剧。顾帆‡找了一张长椅坐下，看着湖水发呆。水下有几条鱼，慢慢地游来游去。他想起了这个星期：一只蝴蝶§，几条鱼，一棵树，一把刀。他发现，这本书从头到尾都没有告诉他该不该辞职。庄子¶什么也没有告诉他，只是让他换了几个地方看自己：在梦里，在桥上，在树下，在厨房里。

31 手机响了两次。第一条是何磊*发来的：“数据出来了。晚上多发两条消息，点开的人确实多了，可是不再用这个应用的人也多了。你赢了一半。下午打球吗？正好把那个问题吵完。”第二条是老宋#的：“星期一早点儿来，带你看看系统最老的那部分。那里的骨头最硬。”顾帆看着这两条消息，笑了很久。

† 什刹海 *Shíchàhǎi* Shichahai (lakes in central Beijing)
‡ 顾帆 *Gù Fān* Gu Fan
§ 蝴蝶 *húdié* butterfly
¶ 庄子 *Zhuāngzǐ* Zhuangzi (the thinker, and his book)
* 何磊 *Hé Lěi* He Lei
老宋 *Lǎo Sòng* Old Song

In November there were few visitors at Shichahai. The leaves on the trees 30
by the lake had turned yellow; a few old people sat chatting by the water, and somewhere in the distance someone was singing Peking opera. Gu Fan found a bench, sat down and gazed at the water. A few fish were swimming slowly back and forth beneath the surface. He thought back over the week: a butterfly, some fish, a tree, a knife. He realised that from beginning to end the book had never told him whether he should resign. Zhuangzi had told him nothing at all; he had only let him look at himself from a few different places: in a dream, on a bridge, under a tree, in a kitchen.

His phone buzzed twice. The first was from He Lei: "The data's in. With 31
two more messages at night, more people did open them, but more people also stopped using the app. You won half. Basketball this afternoon? We can finish that argument while we're at it." The second was from Old Song: "Come in early on Monday and I'll show you the oldest part of the system. That's where the bones are hardest." Gu Fan looked at the two messages and smiled for a long time.

32 然后，他打开了那封信。“我决定辞职。”还是那五个字。他看了很久，在后面又写了几句话，然后按下了一个键。至于他究竟是把信发了出去，还是又一次把它留在了手机里，这里就不说了。也许星期一，他照样坐地铁去公司，坐在九楼最里面的桌子旁边，跟老宋[1]学怎么“解”一个老系统；也许他坐上了回江西[2]的火车，去看那一片油菜花[3]。哪一种都可以。

33 湖里的鱼还在游。它们究竟快乐不快乐，顾帆[4]不知道。不过他想起了书上那个故事的最后：惠子[5]还是不同意，庄子[6]就说，你问我“怎么知道鱼快乐”，说明你已经知道我知道了，才来问我。我是在濠水[7]的桥上知道的。最后一句古文[8]是：“我知之[9]濠[10]上也。”顾帆也知道了一件事：此刻，坐在这里，他是快乐的。

1 老宋 *Lǎo Sòng* Old Song
2 江西 *Jiāngxī* Jiangxi (province)
3 油菜花 *yóucàihuā* rapeseed flowers
4 顾帆 *Gù Fān* Gu Fan
5 惠子 *Huìzǐ* Huizi, Zhuangzi's friend
6 庄子 *Zhuāngzǐ* Zhuangzi (the thinker, and his book)
7 濠水 *Háoshuǐ* the Hao River
8 古文 *gǔwén* classical Chinese
9 之 *zhī* (classical particle)
10 濠 *Háo* the Hao River

Then he opened the letter. "I have decided to resign." The same five characters. He looked at it for a long time, added a few more sentences at the end, and then pressed a key. As for whether he actually sent the letter, or left it on his phone once again, we will not say here. Perhaps on Monday he took the subway to work as usual, sat at the desk at the far end of the ninth floor, and learned from Old Song how to "carve up" an old system; perhaps he boarded a train home to Jiangxi to see those rapeseed fields. Either would be fine. 32

The fish in the lake were still swimming. Whether they were really happy or not, Gu Fan didn't know. But he remembered how that story in the book ended. Huizi still didn't agree, and Zhuangzi said: you asked me "how do you know the fish are happy", which shows you already knew that I knew, and that's why you asked. I knew it on the bridge over the Hao. The last line in classical Chinese was: "I knew it here, above the Hao." And Gu Fan knew one thing too: right now, sitting here, he was happy. 33

33 一片黄叶子从树上落下来，在风里时而高，时而低，像一只蝴蝶†。

† 蝴蝶 *húdié* butterfly

A yellow leaf fell from a tree, rising and dipping in the wind, like a butterfly. 33